

Boston's talent scores a triple

Three local designers win major awards

By Robert Campbell
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Local architecture scored a hat trick in recent weeks.

Three different architects, all with Boston connections, collected major awards.

Boston architects Leers Weinzapfel won the Firm of the Year award. This is a prestigious prize, given annually to only one outstanding US firm by the American Institute of Architects.

Edward Larrabee Barnes won the Gold Medal of the American Institute of Architects. The medal is the AIA's highest lifetime achievement award. Barnes was a Harvard grad and Cambridge resident who died in 2004.

And the Wang Campus Center at Wellesley won the Harleston Parker Medal, an annual award given by the Boston Society of Architects for the best new work of architecture in the Boston area. Wang was designed by Mack Scogin and Merrill Elam of Atlanta.

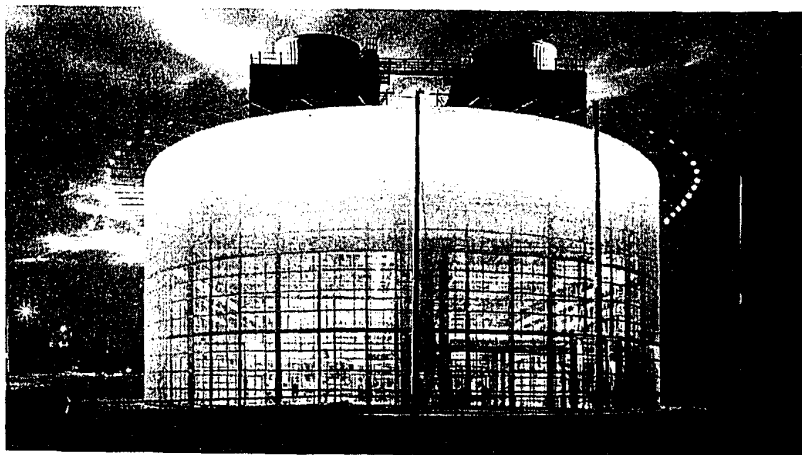
Andrea Leers and Jane Weinzapfel founded their firm in 1982. They too have a Parker Medal, won back in 1996 for the buoyant Blue Hill Avenue Youth Development Center, created from an abandoned hockey rink.

Leers and Weinzapfel are unapologetic modernists. Their buildings tend to be detailed in industrial materials like steel and glass. The AIA press release on the Firm of the Year award quotes words I once wrote in the *Globe*: "Leers and Weinzapfel are architects who take as much delight in a crisply machined joint as an old-time craftsman would take in an ornamental carving."

One of the firm's more astonishing buildings is a chilled-water plant for the University of Pennsylvania. The architects wrapped it in a circular wall of shimmering glass, some 600 feet in circumference. They thus converted the least romantic of all building types into a memorable icon at a gateway to the university.

Leers teaches at Harvard, and Weinzapfel has just stepped down as president of the Boston Society of Architects. Although they hate to be typecast as women, they nevertheless write, in an office brochure, "Young women, in particular, have always sought out the firm and its role models; they are encouraged to learn, thrive, and overcome those hurdles which still exist."

The firm now includes two younger partners, both male. Among local buildings by Leers Weinzapfel are the handsome MBTA Operations Control Center on Atlantic Avenue,



Leers Weinzapfel, which won the Firm of the Year award from the American Institute of Architects, designed this chilled-water plant for the University of Pennsylvania. The building is wrapped in a circular wall of shimmering glass.

and the Tobin Bridge Administration Building, which hangs from the bridge 120 feet above ground. They've done five courthouses. They've worked for both Harvard and MIT, including, currently, the conversion of Harvard's Hasty Pudding Club into a new college theater.

Barnes is only the sixth posthumous winner of the AIA Gold Medal in its 200 years of existence. Thomas Jefferson was another. As an undergrad, Barnes was president of the Harvard Glee Club, and he later taught English at Milton Academy (his mom was a Pulitzer-prize-winning novelist). He returned to Harvard in the early 1940s to study architecture under Walter Gropius, the modernist who founded the Bauhaus school in Germany. Barnes later practiced out of New York but returned to live in Harvard Square in his last years.

Like Leers and Weinzapfel, Barnes remained a convinced modernist all his life. He refused to dabble in passing fads and fashions. His work is usually simple and direct. The most famous example is the Haystack Mountain School of Crafts on Deer Isle in Maine. Here Barnes, for very low cost, created a marvelous village of shingled dorms and workshops that spills down a steep slope toward Blue Hill Bay. His Walker Art Center in Minneapolis is another small-scaled masterpiece.

Barnes wasn't at his best with larger buildings, although his IBM tower on Madison Avenue in New York, its glass atrium filled with bamboo trees, is a winner. The best you can say of his 1969 New England Merchants Bank tower in Boston — now much renovated and known as 28 State Street — is that it was the

most elegant of a generation of not very friendly downtown office buildings.

As for this year's Parker-winning Wang Center at Wellesley, by married partners Scogin and Elam, it's something very different. It bristles with a theatrical zest that's very much of our own time. Parts seem ready to blast out of it in many directions. "It turns, it leans, it pivots," says Peter Fergusson, a professor of art history who was part of Wellesley's client team. "It's faceted, it's fractured. It's a model of looseness, dispersal, indirection, variety." He thinks it mirrors a diverse student body.

The Wang's interior spaces, like the exterior, are loosely shaped and highly varied. They offer a potential site for almost any imaginable student personality or activity. The marvelous landscape, by Michael Van Valkenburgh, is a memory of the natural ponds and drumlins of New England.

Scogin is a former chair of architecture at Harvard's Graduate School of Design, where he still teaches.

It's notable that the Wang arrives in the same year as the new Institute of Contemporary Art on the waterfront. Taken together, these two fine buildings suggest that Boston's love affair with its past may be mellowing — maturing, let's say — and that there's a new acceptance of inventive architecture.

Three architects, three winners: Architecture is healthy in Boston.

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